

12 DAYS, 4,448 ATHLETES, 222 UNIVERSITIES

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The storied state of Rajasthan added another chapter to its history as it welcomed young sportspersons from far and wide across the country for the fifth edition of the Khelo India University Games.

Adding to the crowd from the peak tourist season, over 12 days, 4,448 athletes from 222 universities flocked to seven cities — Jaipur, Ajmer, Udaipur, Jodhpur, Bikaner, Kota and Bharatpur — which served as hosts.

And while the numbers set it up for a big spectacle, the competition found itself questioning its relevance in the calendar, being slightly marred by shallow turnouts in some disciplines.

With an all-time high of 23 events held, it was Chandigarh University (**facing page**) that retained its crown with a commanding haul of 67 medals (42 gold, 14 silver and 11 bronze). **A chunk of the institution's success was due to its prowess in the newly added event of canoeing and kayaking, where it bagged 23 gold medals, one silver and one bronze each.**

Lovely Professional University (32 gold, 25 silver and 22 bronze)

and Guru Nanak Dev University (32 gold, 22 silver and 18 bronze) completed the podium. There were some seasoned faces around.

Champion swimmer Srihari Nataraj was the cream of the crop and the best individual performer, securing 11 medals (nine gold and two silver) for Jain University, helping it settle into fourth place in the overall tally. Elsewhere, the shooting events were headlined by Asian Games medallists Sift Kaur Samra and Ashi Chouksey. While the two combined to secure a bronze for GNDU in the women's 50m rifle 3 positions team event, it was Ashi who came out on top in the individual event for her fourth straight gold in the competition, while Sift had to settle for silver.

In the men's competition, Olympic medallist Sarabjot Singh too had a fruitful outing, winning bronze in the men's 10m air pistol, silver in the men's 10m air pistol team event and gold in the 10m air pistol mixed team category for Panjab University.

Meanwhile, the choice to stage the Games in the middle of winter in the region came with its own set of challenges. Early sunsets and temperatures dropping to close to 10 degrees Celsius discouraged many individuals from participating and disrupted their time off, with athletics

Charging ahead: Animesh Kujur (in pic), along with D. Mrutyam Jayaram, Santa Mahendra and Abhay Singh, set a meet record time of 40.09s in the 4x100m final. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

